HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"It's been a transformation"

For 45-year-old Dr Ghulam Abbas, the 1,000-kilometre road trip between Delhi and hometown Siwan in Bihar, crossing the entire length of Uttar Pradesh, has been a regular part of life for years. "Waiting at toll plazas was one of the most frustrating parts of the journey," he says. "Long queues, arguments over exact change, and wasted time made the drive exhausting."

However, all of that changed with the introduction of FASTag. "It's been a complete transformation," says Dr Abbas. "Now, I can drive through toll plazas without stopping."



DR S. GHULAM ABBAS, 45
Consultant (General Medicine), Indraprastha Apollo Hospital, Delhi

Dr Abbas keeps his FASTag wallet topped up with at least Rs 2,000 to ensure uninterrupted travel. "It is the most handy thing," he says, praising the quick online recharges plus instant transaction alerts. Crossing states or dealing with different toll rates rarely brings hassle with FASTag. "In all these years, I encountered a technical glitch at a toll plaza just once—and even that resolved quickly."

The impact has been profound for Dr Abbas in both his personal and professional life. "I focus more on my journey, reach destinations faster, plus enjoy travel," he said. FASTag, he says, is not just a toll payment tool. "It saves my time. And for a doctor, time saved is lives saved." ■

with issues like cash handling, fake bills and the constant risk of theft. As India's highway network expanded, so did the volume of traffic, and the floundering system meant a daily challenge for millions of commuters, and losses to the economy.

THE EASE OF LIVING

Enter FASTag, a small Bandaid-like sticker on your windshield, and travel on Indian highways has never been the same. A simple radio frequency identification (RFID)-based solution, it made contactless toll payments real, eliminating cash transactions and, hence, the queues. Launched in 2014, it was based on a simple premise—One Nation, One Tag.

FASTag became mandatory for all vehicles in February 2021, and new cars began coming with FASTags in place. From 485 million FASTags issued in FY22, the number has already reached 876 million this year up to January 2025. The number of transactions in this time has gone up from 2.4 billion to 3.1 billion. The change has been dramatic. According to a study commissioned by the National Highways Authority of India, FASTag had brought the average waiting time at toll booths from 734 seconds down to just 47. The intent is to reduce it now to 10 seconds.

Strategic planning has made FASTag's widespread use possible. ""FASTag has revolutionised toll payments, paving the way for a cashless, efficient economy," says Vishal Chauhan, CMD of Indian Highways Management Company Limited (IHMCL). "Building on this foundation, we are now piloting barrierless systems with automatic number plate recognition cameras, a step towards smarter, seamless highway operations."

Besides individual convenience, FASTag has improved revenue collection. The plan now is to go beyond FASTag to global navigation satellite-based tolling

Currently, over 98 per cent of tolls are collected through FASTag. The system also gives instant transaction alerts through SMS plus email, allowing users to keep track and recharge online, if need be. For commercial fleet operators, FASTag has created new ways to manage toll expenses and track vehicle movement. The digital trail helps with better accounting along with reducing the risk of pilferage. Emergency vehicles that use FASTag enjoy faster passage through toll plazas, potentially saving really critical minutes in dire situations.

Besides individual convenience, FASTag has also improved revenue collection, shoring up government finances crucial for infrastructure development. Toll collections could surpass Rs 70,000 crore by the end of FY25, compared to Rs 38,000 crore in FY22. In fact, India is now planning to go beyond FASTag to global navigation satellite-based tolling which could eliminate the need for toll booths altogether. And with it, the remaining hassles in the journey by road. ■